

The next move, according to history.

Question: what should LiveQue do next to go viral among gigging musicians who play covers and originals? Five research agents worked separate evidence angles (musician-tool history, diffusion science, gen-Z channels, failure autopsies, scene-density playbooks), a red team attacked the candidates, and a synthesis committed to one answer. All five angles converged on the same move.

THE MOVE

Saturate one home open mic: Glen plays it every week with the QR sign on stage, converts the host first via a live \$2-into-the-host's-own-Stripe demo, seeds the first queue-jump every night so the room always sees money visibly move a song, and recruits 4-6 of the room's regulars — with a hard 8-week tip-or-switch-rooms gate before spending a single guitar pick anywhere else.

The metric that says it is working

Weekly-active non-founder performers at the home open mic — the count of regulars (excluding Isaac and Glen) who ran LiveQue on stage this week without prompting. Target: 4-6 (about 25% of a ~20-performer roster) by week 8; if under 2 by week 8, switch to the backup room. Not signups, not reach — this one number is the Centola threshold made countable.

Why history says so

- The fastest musician-to-musician cascade in history was hand-seeded in exactly LiveQue's position: MySpace's founders personally recruited LA club-scene bands one at a time (Tom Anderson DM'd unsigned artists individually), and bands' profiles/flyers made the product visible at the point of use — 0 to 5M users in 15 months. LiveQue's QR stage sign is the same flyer, and Isaac and Glen are the same small LA team courting the same scene.

Julia Angwin, 'Stealing MySpace' (2009); Stereogum, 'The My Generation: An Oral History of Myspace Music' (2020)

- A committed ~25% of a bounded group flips the group's norm abruptly; below that, efforts consistently fail. An open mic's 15-25 recurring performers is a bounded group, so 4-6 weekly users is the experimentally demonstrated tipping target — and adoption is a complex contagion needing repeated exposures from multiple different peers inside one tight cluster, which is why one room weekly beats all of LA thinly.

Centola et al., 'Experimental Evidence for Tipping Points in Social Convention,' Science 360 (2018); Centola, 'The Spread of Behavior in an Online Social Network Experiment,' Science 329 (2010)

- Seeding hubs is up to 8x more effective than random seeding, and in-venue music tech only ever survived by winning the in-room stakeholder (TouchTunes built 63,000 venues through operators, not consumers). The open-mic host is LiveQueue's hub-operator: on stage every week in front of every rotating performer, and their own use makes the QR the room's default.

Hinz, Skiera, Barrot & Becker, 'Seeding Strategies for Viral Marketing,' *Journal of Marketing* 75(6) (2011); TouchTunes history via SEC Form S-4 (Victory Acquisition Corp, 2009)

- Imitation drives adoption ~10x more than external influence (average Bass $q \approx 0.39$ vs $p \approx 0.03$), and passive-broadcast visibility built into normal product use generates ~2.5x more contagion than asking for referrals — quantitative permission to spend \$0 on ads and everything on making the queue-jump visibly happen on stage, narrated from the mic.

Sultan, Farley & Lehmann, 'A Meta-Analysis of Applications of Diffusion Models,' *JMR* (1990); Aral & Walker, 'Creating Social Contagion Through Viral Product Design,' *Management Science* 57(9) (2011)

- Depth-before-breadth is the only pattern that wins bounded real-world networks: Facebook saturated Harvard to ~75% in one month before campus #2; Tinder went 5k to 15k users by exhausting one campus scene at a time; Square spread because farmers-market buyers watched the reader work at the point of transaction. The corollary gate: if the home room hasn't tipped in 8 weeks, the room was wrong — switch rooms, don't abandon the strategy.

The Harvard Crimson, 'Hundreds Register for New Facebook Website' (Feb 2004); TechCrunch, 'The Story Of Whitney Wolfe Vs. Tinder' (2014); Product Habits, 'How Square Became a \$30 Billion Company'

- Musicians convert only after personally watching real money move — Busk.co's performers were hostile for seven years until they felt lost cash tips, and passive Venmo QR signs get 5% usage while staged, prompted moments get 30-40%. So the first queue-jump each night must be deliberately seeded (the \$2 test, a friend, Isaac remotely) so the observable result fires every single week; a seeded first tip is a demo that primes real ones.

The Busking Project blog, 'Looking back at the last ten years' (2024); NBC News/CNBC, 'Street performers rely on apps like Venmo as cash fades' (2025)

- The category's #1 killer is touching the artist's money — PledgeMusic collapsed owing artists ~£7.5M, Sessions vanished with unpaid balances despite \$75M — and charging musicians (Sonicbids) triggers unforgivable distrust. LiveQueue's Stripe-direct, 0%, never-touches-the-money architecture is the trust wedge against 10+ feature-parity clones; it goes on the sign, the cards, and in the host demo script, and money must never pool in anyone else's account (no house-QR fallback through the host).

Digital Music News, 'The Rise and Fall of PledgeMusic' (2019); Billboard Pro, 'Livestreaming Platform Sessions Shuts Down' (2023); Digital Music News on Sonicbids (2013)

The 30-day plan

Week 1 (Jul 28 - Aug 3): Pick the room, fix the demo path

- Pick ONE home open mic from Glen's existing rooms using three criteria: friendliest host relationship, real civilian (non-performer) audience that tips, and a night Glen can make every single week regardless of Isaac's VFX crunch. Predefine the backup room now.
- Close the open \$2 live-tip test on Isaac's own account end-to-end (scan, Apple Pay, queue jump, Stripe payout visible) and time Stripe Express onboarding on a phone; if it's over ~3 minutes in bar conditions, Isaac fixes the flow this week — the whole host demo depends on it.
- Write and rehearse the 60-second host demo script: pull up the artist page on your phone, host scans on THEIR phone, host onboards their OWN Stripe Express, a \$2 tip lands in the HOST's account while they watch. Never demo money landing in Isaac's account.
- Print two On-Air-brand QR stage signs with the result, not the logo: 'Tips move your song up. Artist keeps 100% — straight to YOUR Stripe.'
- Write one 15-second stage-patter line for Glen to say once per set when a tip lands ('someone just paid \$2 to jump that song up the list').

Week 2 (Aug 3 - 9): Convert the host, run night #1 — swag lands Aug 5

- Glen plays the home room with the QR sign up; before or after his set, run the 60-second host demo and get the host onboarded to their own Stripe for their host sets. Title them 'Founding Host' on the spot.
- Seed the first queue-jump of the night (Isaac remotely or a planted friend sends \$2) so the room reliably sees a song visibly move; then let organic tips follow. Do this every week without fail — the 8-week gate clock starts this night.
- Swag arrives Aug 5: hand picks and 9V battery cards ONLY to musicians who just watched the tip move the queue, at this room only. No blanket handouts, no other venues.
- Mount a phone and film every queue-jump moment. This is a proof archive, not a channel — no posting targets.
- Capture every interested musician's email/phone directly into LiveQue's own list the moment they express interest. No platform sits between LiveQue and its performers.

Week 3 (Aug 10 - 16): First non-founder adopters

- Target the first 2 non-family regulars: walk each through Stripe Express on the spot at the gig on their own phone, and get them to run LiveQue during their own slot that same night.
- Badge the first users 'LA Founding Artists' in-product and tell them that's what they are — status is the only currency needed and it's free.
- Isaac (async, weekend): batch-edit the filmed clips into a 30-second proof reel — the thing Glen texts a hesitant regular or a second host, not a TikTok campaign.
- Glen keeps the weekly cadence: sign up, seeded first tip, patter line, swag only to witnesses. Isaac does not need to attend; his job is product friction and editing.
- Log the room's roster: names of recurring performers seen so far — this is the denominator for the metric.

Week 4 (Aug 17 - 26): Cadence, measurement, and the gate

- Repeat the full night ritual; push for 3+ non-founder regulars having run LiveQue on stage at least once, with at least 1 using it unprompted a second week.
- Ask the Founding Host to mention it once from the mic as the room's way to request songs — the host saying it is the first non-founder peer exposure, which is when the contagion clock really starts.
- Review the gate at day 30: on pace is 2+ unprompted repeat users trending to 4-6 by week 8. If zero non-founder adoption and a cold host, invoke the backup room early rather than waiting the full 8 weeks.
- Explicitly do NOT: post in Facebook gig groups, publish vs-competitor content, start a TikTok posting schedule, pitch new venues, or plan NAMM activation. All of it waits for the room to tip.
- Isaac (async): confirm every adopter's email + Stripe connection is captured directly, and prep the one-sentence sustainability answer ('how do you make money?') for when forum testimony activates later.

What the red team killed

TikTok as the growth engine: demoted to exhaust. Film every queue-jump, but it is a private proof archive for convincing hesitant hosts and regulars, not a posting schedule. It activates only after the home room tips.

Facebook-group / Reddit testimony: demoted to messaging. The zero-percent, straight-to-your-Stripe line goes on the sign, the cards, and the host demo script. Posting it anywhere activates only when non-founder users have real earnings screenshots, and even then reply-only to organic threads.

Explicitly do not (for 30 days): post in gig groups, publish competitor comparisons, start a TikTok cadence, pitch new venues, or plan the NAMM activation. All of it waits for the room to tip.

Runners-up and when they wake

- TikTok/Reels as a growth channel — peer-voiced clips of a tip visibly jumping a song up the queue, posted from Isaac and Glen's personal performer accounts (the Bad Monkey / #GuitarTok pattern).

Activates when: The home room generates authentic weekly tip moments with real fans and real reactions (i.e., after the room has tipped). Until then, filming continues every gig but stays a private proof archive used to convert hesitant hosts and regulars — no posting cadence, no growth targets.

- Zero-fee testimony in 20k-50k-member Facebook gig groups and Reddit — answering organic 'how do you handle requests?' threads with real earnings screenshots and 'straight to MY Stripe, the app takes nothing', plus DistroKid-style comparison content.

Activates when: There exist real multi-gig earnings screenshots from NON-founder users AND a crisp one-sentence sustainability answer to 'then how do you make money?'. Even then: reply-only to organic threads, never initiated, ideally posted by Founding Artists rather than the founders — the community bans promotion and pattern-matches astroturf.

The one warning from the autopsies

Every dead competitor in this category died one of two ways: touching the artist's money (PledgeMusic collapsed owing artists ~£7.5M; Sessions vanished with unpaid balances despite \$75M raised) or charging musicians for exposure (Sonicbids). LiveQue's architecture - Stripe-direct, 0%, money never pools

anywhere - is the trust wedge. Say it everywhere, and never break it, including no house-QR fallback that routes tips through a host.

Key sources

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